issues. In 2019, Mona decided to revive the company as RESHMONA, an online brand. "I installed a burner in my balcony to experiment with different herb mixes," she says. These were then sent to the laboratory in Kanpur for fine-tuning and development of market-ready formulations. The company ships to customers across India today and is exploring opportunities to export to UAE and Australia.

Unlike traditional brick-and-mortar businesses, the digital landscape today allows home-based women entrepreneurs to connect to, and reach, customers globally. Often informally run, these women-run businesses also provide employment opportunities to other women and are managing to reach impressive heights. The latest available figures are from the 2017-18 Periodic Labour Force Survey, according to which there are 12.48 million women home-based workers in India comprising 26.5 per cent of all employed workers.

"Even if only 5-10 per cent of these home businesses achieve substantial size and one per cent achieve scale, it's still significant. Unlike startups, of which 99 per cent fail, these businesses work on an asset-light model, have significantly lower mortality rates and are usually profitable from day one," says Sairee Chahal, founder-chairperson of Mahila Money, a financial services platform for women.

However, such informal businesses still require a supportive ecosystem of the kind that has been developed for startups in the form of access to credit, formalisation support, upskilling and market linkages, according to the IWWAGE report. A 2022 report by the International Finance Corporation (IFC) estimates a credit demand of Rs 83,600 crore by very small women-owned enterprises. "Many women entrepreneurs don't have a digital trail or credit history essential for them to access capital. They also often don't own assets or property in their name, so securing collateral-based loans is difficult," says Preethi Rao, director, partnership & outreach at LEAD (Leveraging Evidence for Access and Development), Krea University.

Some businesses, many of them helmed by women, have already identified the gap and apply the gender lens to investing so that they can help home-based women entrepreneurs to reach their full potential. Chahal, for instance, started Mahila Money in 2021 to extend micro loans to women-led businesses, in the range of Rs 30,000 to Rs 25 lakh. Of the 1 million women Mahila Money has given loans to since inception, more than half have increased their incomes by at least 50 per cent, claims Chahal.

There is also Mumbai-based peer-to-peer lending platform IndiaP2P that enables investors—not banks—to lend directly to women business owners. "Women are the best asset class and borrowers with the lowest NPAs [non-performing assets], yet they find it difficult to access loans through mainstream avenues," says IndiaP2P co-founder Neha Juneja. Since its incorporation in 2021, IndiaP2P has assisted over 300,000 women borrowers, she says.

Shows like *Shark Tank* have also helped Indians gain understanding of entrepreneurship like never before and opened up the possibility of dreaming and striving toward it. It has also given home-based women entrepreneurs like Kalpana exposure and recognition. After JhaJi was featured on *Shark Tank India* Season 1, the company recorded sales worth Rs 7.5 lakh within the next two hours, says Kalpana.

So overwhelming was the response that Kalpana says they had to temporarily shut down their website, owing to lack of inventory. A very confident Kalpana today anticipates closing the current fiscal with revenues between Rs 8 crore and Rs 10 crore, even as she is busy planning the company's vision for the next 10 years. Buying automated machinery, planning for exports and introducing a range of food products and spice mixes are keeping her aspirations and ambitions high. ■

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR



- Company: **TryKiya.com**
- Founders: **Punanya Virmani** (standing) and **Mili Anand Agrawal**
- When: **2021**
- Where: **New Delhi**
- Business: **D2C sampling marketplace**
- FY 2023 Turnover: **₹1.5 crore**